C1 Speaking

Giving feedback diplomatically

Praise, criticise and suggest improvements to colleagues or classmates in a way that is honest but tactful.

Giving feedback is one of the hardest things to do well in a second language. Too direct sounds rude; too soft and the message is lost. C1 speakers use a clear structure and softening language to keep both the relationship and the message.

Step	Language
Start with something specific and positive	*I really liked the way you opened with a question.*
Introduce the issue gently	*One thing you might want to look at is… I wonder if…*
Describe the effect, not the person	*The middle section felt a little long, so some people lost focus.*
Suggest, don't order	*Perhaps you could… It might be worth trying…*
Check and encourage	*Does that make sense? Overall, it's a really strong start.*

Use softeners. *A bit, slightly, a little, not quite* and the past continuous (*I was wondering whether…*) reduce the force of criticism without changing its meaning.

Common mistake. Using *but* immediately after praise: *Great work, but…* makes listeners ignore the praise. Try *and* or a full stop: *Great work. One thing to build on is…*

Practice

A colleague has just given a presentation. Make each piece of feedback more diplomatic.

1. Your slides had too much text.
2. You spoke too fast.

3. Start with specific praise about their examples.
4. Suggest, don't order: Add a summary at the end.
5. Finish the feedback encouragingly.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Some of the slides were a little text-heavy, so it was hard to read and listen at the same time.
2. At times the pace was slightly fast, so a few key points were easy to miss.
3. The real examples you used made the data much easier to understand.
4. It might be worth adding a short summary at the end.
5. Overall, it was a really clear presentation, and these are just small things to polish.